G.W. Carver High School: Building New Orleans' Next Generation Of Academic Scholars

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This interview was conducted with Dwana Caliste, Health Teacher and Athletic Director, and proud G.W. Carver High School alum.

For eleven years, G.W. Carver High School existed without a home. Hurricane Katrina scattered its students, displaced its faculty, and left its campus on Higgins Boulevard in the Ninth Ward sitting empty. But Carver never stopped being Carver. When the school finally returned to its original location in 2016, it wasn't just a reopening. It was a statement. Since its founding in 1958, Carver has been a cornerstone of the Ninth Ward, offering students in grades 9-12 academic programs, and enriching extracurricular activities including athletics, creative, and musical clubs, along with a community that supports them. Today, two decades after the storm, Carver is still here, and still building.

Few people understand what that continuity means better than Dwana Caliste. A Carver alum herself, she now walks the same halls as a Health Teacher and Athletic Director, investing in the next generation the way her own community once invested in her. We sat down with Dwana to talk about BCM's role in Carver's work, what resilience really looks like twenty years out, and the legacy she hopes her scholars carry with them long after graduation.

Q: How has BCM's funding and support opened doors that might not have otherwise been possible for G.W. Carver?

Dwana Caliste: I think BCM funding has opened a lot of doors when you think about things that don't happen without extra resources. Resources like reading intervention and other programs that help our scholars who may need additional push and support to succeed. So, when you get extra resources and funding from organizations that believe in the community around them, it allows us to open doors that would traditionally not get those extra resources. Those extra bodies, extra eyes, and extra time go a long way. It is saying that BCM cares about us and cares about education.

Q: Twenty years after Hurricane Katrina, what does G.W. Carver's existence say about New Orleans' resilience and the community's ability to rebuild on its own terms?

DC: Carver's testament after the storm is that we are here to stay. Carver's resilience not only showed that yes, it was devastating and you can't take that back, but what [we] could do is show a sense of hope, pride, and legacy. And Carver does that time and time again. Since 1958, Carver has always been a beacon of light within this community. And we get to continue that when there are organizations like BCM who have the belief and faith in how [we are guiding] these students and investing in our longevity.

Q: What is the legacy you hope your students will leave behind for future students and the community to be inspired by?

DC: Our vision and our values should stick with students, from Carver and beyond.
The vision of George Washington Carver High School is to prepare all scholars for college success, inspired and ready to exceed any expectation. Our values include achievement, kindness, responsibility, determination, teamwork, and enthusiasm. What is also important is how we, the educators, made the students feel. Our scholars come to school ready to engage and ready to be challenged. Our legacy has to be that scholars came here ready, and I want all of our scholars to say, I enjoyed every moment at Carver. That they enjoyed being seen, heard and celebrated. That is why we as educators are all doing this work.

Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see Carver playing in the continued recovery and reimaging of New Orleans?

DC: For me, especially as a Carver alum, I like to think that [we] will consistently guide the way, and kids need to see consistency in order to grow, be excellent, and to come into who they are. I think for the next 20 years, Carver is on the path to getting it right. I think that is because we have so many culture bearers in the building and people who know what it was like to lose everything in the storm and come back. We often say it is business as usual, but it is definitely not like that, and it can't be when you have

lost loved ones. So, putting care at the forefront of our work is what Carver has done and what we have gotten right. For the next 20 years, if we continue to move forward with care and bring attention to detail to the forefront of what we are doing, we are going to be here for a very long time. That is the reason why we are still here. We care for these kids. We care for their families. And we care for their well-being. That is why we are still here and will continue to be.

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